

options, hit F4 and select the display resolution, there and then. On my Intel-based wide-screen laptop (which uses a resolution of 1200x800 pixels), things worked all right without any manual intervention.

KDEExperience

Sabayon comes with a custom themed version of KDE 4.3.1 (v4.3.2 is not available in the software repository yet). Instead of the stock Air theme introduced in KDE 4.3, Sabayon uses Elegance—a dark theme that gels well with the overall Sabayon 5 look and feel. And unlike other distros, a number of other desktop themes are preinstalled to let you customise the desktop the way you want without requiring to download additional themes. Additionally, it comes with a decent collection of wallpapers too, and Kwin effects work out-of-the-box if you have a capable graphics card.

The resolution of panel is awkwardly set at a width of 1024px, leaving some blank space on both sides of a screen with a resolution of 1280x1024px (or, any resolution where the screen width is more than 1024px). Well, many not-so-mainstream distros have a fetish for this sort of a Mac OS X-ish panel setting, which sort of seems odd considering the fact that the rest of the screen on the left and right side of panel goes waste. Anyway, we all know how to set this straight, don't we? Strangely, essential shortcuts like 'Show Desktop' and 'Battery Indicator' (for laptop users) are missing from the panel. Again, we know how to take care of this.

While the stock KDE only has 'System Settings', a home directory shortcut for Dolphin and the Konqueror Web browser as our default 'favourites' in the Kickoff application launcher, Sabayon has added more natural fits for our favourites here (Firefox, Kopete, KTorrent, Konversation IRC client, Amarok, VLC Player, OOo Writer and Calc). However, I believe a home directory shortcut would have been a better selection instead of an IRC client; besides, 'System Settings' is also an essential app for those who like to tinker with their system frequently.

The default installation comes with lots of handy applications for most desktop requirements, but some of the essential apps like Digikam (digital camera tool) and the GIMP are missing. As for an image viewer/manager, Gwenview is also missing. So accessing images means opening them in the Okular document viewer. Of course, these can be had from the official software repository. In fact, although it comes with the Firefox 3.5 as the default browser, the repo also offers Chromium (open source Google Chrome) as an alternative.

After using Chromium for a week, I found it to be pretty stable. I'll definitely recommend it over FF simply because of the well-thought-out UI which gives you much more screen space to view Web pages, compared to any other browser, besides the ability to run multiple incognito windows (private browsing sessions). Coming back to FF (and even in Chromium), one good thing is that mime



Figure 1: KDE Live desktop

types are properly set. So you'll have no problem in directly opening e-mail attachments, or for that matter, when you download anything from the Web, straight inside the required application.

By the way, wireless connection on my Intel Wi-Fi based laptop worked out-of-the-box. What I also noticed is the NetworkManager system tray widget has been cleaned up a lot. I don't remember seeing this polish when KDE 4.3 first came out. What struck me as surprising was the inclusion of the Wicd network manager—which is basically redundant!

Sabayon comes with most of the multimedia codes preinstalled. So whether you throw DVD videos at it or DivX files, VLC should be able to take care of it all. Amarok, on the other hand, takes care of your MP3 music collection. The version is 1.1.80 (2.2 beta)—the final 2.2 version is yet to be made available in the repo. Note that although this version reintroduces an equaliser, yet it's greyed out in Sabayon. Besides these two power apps, you also have the minimalist Dragon Player and the XBMC media centre application.

The version of OpenOffice.org is 3.1. It comes with an integrated Oxygen icon theme by default, which means better KDE integration because the icons don't look out of place in KDE4 any more. However, the KDE4 integration is nowhere near complete—the *Save as/Open file* dialogue boxes are still that of the stock OOo, instead of being KDE4 based. Apart from this, English spelling packs are missing. Another thing to note here is that font rendering inside OOo and Firefox are not anti-aliased out-of-the-box—which makes them look a bit crooked.



Figure 2: Default Kickoff favourites